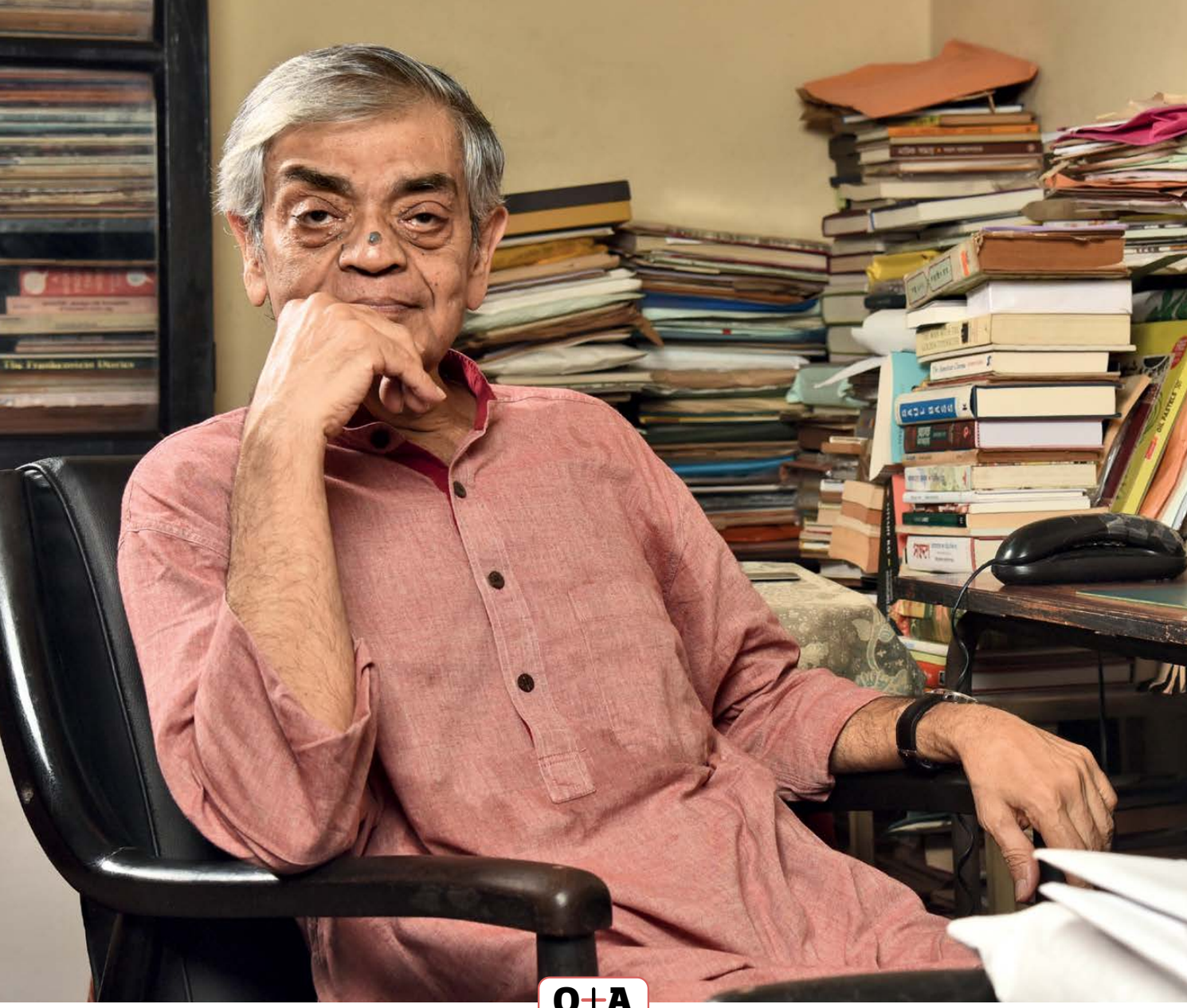


Q+A

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

# FATHERS AND SONS

Filmmaker **Sandip Ray** reveals several unknown facets of his legendary father Satyajit Ray in Ashoke Nag's *Ray on Ray*

**Q. What made it possible for Satyajit Ray to leave behind such a prolific body of work?**

Time management. He would work as much as possible in a day. Wake up by 7 or 8, respond to letters first thing in the morning. Then, move to illustrations for his magazine *Sandesh* and other commissioned works. Then, he would write. He was a very fast writer, finishing a short story in two days, a novel in seven.

**Q. If he was still around, what subject would he choose for a film?**

Except for a couple of his own screenplays, he always made film adaptations from literature. So, I am guessing he would adapt yet again. He was not particularly keen on directly making films on burning political issues, or pointedly make a film on the times, because he felt that the issue should be a backdrop for a story on human relationships.

**Q. What images come to mind when you think about your father?**

My memories of him mostly have to do with seeing him at work, either on set, or at the editing table. Anybody who worked with him misses seeing him working. I remember, during shooting the house he was born in while making a documentary on his father, the writer Sukumar Ray, he declined to go in. He said, everything has changed inside, I would rather have my own memory of the place.

**Q. What are you working on next?**

Given the situation of Kolkata right now [protests over the R.G. Kar Medical College incident], mounting a film project is unthinkable. But perhaps, I will make an anthology film based on short stories. Audience attention spans are abysmal now. They cannot sit through a film without surfing their phones. Might as well make 30-minute short films and bring them together, so the stories stay snappy.

**–with Devarsi Ghosh**